visited China in 1993. On all these occasions the border problem was kept aside and negotiations were held in other fields of interests of both the countries.

Rao also tried to improve India's relation, with her neighbours, especially with Nepal, though with Sri Lanka there remained a little irritant over forcing a SAARC Summit in the absence of the Bhutanese King. Indo–Pak relations continued to be strained following the accelerated pace of development of Pak's nuclear capability with assistance from China and North Korea. Further, the demolition of Babri Masjid on 7 December 1992 deteriorated the relation between the two.

I.K. Gujral (1997–1998): The Gujral Doctrine

The 11th Lok Sabha elections resulted in a hung Parliament and two years of political instability during which the country had three Prime Ministers. First A.B.Vajpayee took over as the Prime Minister on May 16 and tried to get support from the regional parties in Parliament. He failed and resigned 13 days later. Then Janata Dal leader Deve Gowda formed a United Front coalition government on 1 June 1996. His government lasted 18 months. I.K. Gujral, who was the Foreign Minister in Gowda's cabinet, took over as the Prime Minister in April 1997 after the Congress agreed to support a new United Front Government from outside. But Gujral was an interim arrangement. The country witnessed another round of elections again in 1998.

The United Front Government, first under Deve Gowda and then under I.K. Gujral did not introduce any significant change in India's foreign policy posture. Both inherited a stable economy registering a good rate of growth. The foreign exchange position also showed improvement. The most noteworthy contribution was made by Prime Minister I.K. Gujral who gave to the world an innovative doctrine. This came to be identified as the *Gujral Doctrine* and it was chalked with a vision to improve India's relations with her neighbours without expecting reciprocity. India held out unilateral concessions to the neighbouring countries in matters relating to trade and travel without expecting reciprocity. The basis of his thought was that India being the largest country in the region could afford to be more generous while protecting her fundamental interests.